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Cruel Optimism, Lucid Despair, and Precarious Hope in HRI

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Abstract

HRI 2026 takes place amid profound socio-political turbulence marked by rising authoritarianism, the consolidation of technological power, and the expanding use of robotics for warfare. These global conditions create an affective atmosphere that seeps into our field: a mix of attachment to techno-determinist and techno-solutionist narratives, unease with 'business as usual,' and a tentative search for alternatives. As HRI scholars and designers, we recognize how the wider socio-political tensions resonate within our own practices, shaping what we take to be possible, necessary, or inevitable in research and design. In this half-day, in-person workshop, we mobilize three affective orientations – cruel optimism, lucid despair, and precarious hope – as resources for reflection, critique, and experimentation. Through short provocations, discussions, and a speculative group activity, participants will be invited to inhabit these affects to question dominant narratives that sustain HRI, confront systemic challenges, and collectively explore alternative trajectories for research, design, and community building.

CCS Concepts

• **Social and professional topics** → **Codes of ethics**; • **Human-centered computing** → **Human computer interaction (HCI)**.

Keywords

critical HRI, technopolitics, politics of HRI, epistemic luddism, affect

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1 Introduction

The motivation for this workshop arose out of the shared sense that something is deeply unsettled. We are witnessing renewed authoritarian tendencies globally and the consolidation of power among a small group of tech oligarchs. One of the prominent – and troubling – domains of application of technologies, including robotics, is warfare [2], where both remotely piloted and autonomous drones have emerged as a new and destructive class of weapon. However, even in the domains ostensibly oriented toward benign or supportive functions, robotic systems are frequently appropriated in ways that consolidate the power of large technology corporations and the individuals who control them. This often carries significant social and environmental costs, including the displacement of human labor and the intensification of ecological harms [5]. In relation to these socio-technical conditions, Brian Merchant has described a contemporary "Luddite renaissance," a resurgence of grassroots collectives, organizations, and clubs undertaking refusal, sabotage, and collective resistance to technologies that deepen exploitation and oppression [6].

These socio-technical and political dynamics together generate a pervasive affective atmosphere that seeps into our professional field, Human-Robot Interaction (HRI): everything feels suspended, though nothing stands still. The crisis we sense globally resonates within our own research practices, shaping what we take to be possible, purposeful, necessary, or inevitable. Tracing the roots of this global and professional situation is less about finding a single cause than recognizing the overlapping forces that bind the global and the local, the professional and the personal, into a shared, palpable tension. Lauren Berlant calls such moments a "situation" [1]: a state in which something that will matter is already unfolding amid the ordinary activity of life. For HRI, this situation poses a pressing question: how can the field break from a model of 'business as usual' that reproduces and amplifies existing inequities, and instead cultivate practices that enable more equitable and affirmative futures for those with whom – and for whom – we design and build robotic systems, but also for ourselves as researchers, practitioners and citizens?

We see this workshop as a way to collectively experiment with alternative trajectories for HRI, ones that open paths to different forms of inhabiting the present and foregrounding more desirable futures. This requires that we explicitly attend to the politics

embedded both within robotic technologies – but also our epistemic practices – recognizing that technical design decisions are entangled with social, economic, political, and cultural forces [3, 7].

2 Workshop Aims and Themes

We aim to cultivate the workshop as a space in which HRI and social sciences scholars, designers, practitioners, and artists can critically address the status quo and collectively experiment with new trajectories and genres of HRI research and design. Through the workshop themes, we mobilize the field's circulating affects – metaphorically grounded through cruel optimism, lucid despair and precarious hope – as explicit resources that reinstate the agency of HRI researchers, end-users, and publics, thereby advancing the HRI 2026 theme, *HRI Empowering Society*.

For us, the first step toward reorienting toward the politics of robotics and HRI is to recognize the dominant narratives that sustain the field: the stories of progress, inevitability, and benevolent automation that shape how we imagine our work, its purposes, and its possibilities [4]. We understand these attachments as a form of *cruel optimism* – sustaining fantasies that both motivate and constrain us, keeping us invested in trajectories that may no longer serve collective flourishing [1].

The second step involves confronting what happens when those sustaining narratives begin to crack. We call this orientation *lucid despair*. Rather than treating despair as an endpoint, we understand it as a way of seeing more clearly what no longer works, and of resisting the impulse to simply repair or move on too quickly. Drawing on Langdon Winner's notion of epistemic Luddism [8], we approach despair as an opportunity to unplug – to pause, refuse, or discontinue practices that perpetuate harm, exhaustion, or complicity. Through this orientation, we invite participants to inhabit discomfort and uncertainty as spaces of insight and resistance rather than paralysis.

The third step, *precarious hope*, gestures toward the search for difference. We understand hope not as naïve optimism about better futures, but as a fragile, deliberate and precarious practice of inhabiting the present otherwise. Where despair opens the space of refusal, hope holds generative potential: the tentative crafting of new genres of research and design, new collaborative formats, and new ways of thinking, making, and feeling together. In this sense, hope becomes both a method and a collective experiment, a way of reimagining how HRI, as a field and community, could be otherwise.

While the three affective orientations – cruel optimism, lucid despair, and precarious hope – may appear to suggest a linear progression, we understand them instead as coexisting and entangled modes of thought, feeling and epistemic practice. We see this oscillation as a productive space of generative multiplicity that allows us to face complexity, contradictions and tensions, and to imagine how HRI might unfold differently.

3 Workshop Format

This will be a half-day, in-person workshop. Throughout the workshop, participants will be invited to embody each affect, oscillating between critique, refusal, and experimentation. The workshop will kick off with a brief round of playful introductions by participants based on their submissions. The introductions will be followed by a series of 'provocations' – short talks by invited speakers, designed to evoke and amplify each affect. Each provocation will be followed by a 20-minute group discussion, inviting participants and speakers to weave connections across themes, tensions, and possibilities.

After a short coffee break, the second part of the workshop will focus on collective experimentation. In small groups, participants will be invited to formulate speculative changes to future editions of the HRI conference, including alternative locations, themes, tracks, and research formats. This exercise will be based on themes constructed from the submissions by the participants themselves. The aim here is not to propose a fixed future but to experiment with speculative genres of research practices, new modes of knowledge production, and community-building that might sustain us differently in the present. To conclude the exercise, each group will present their suggested changes in a speculative conference opening speech (on the main stage on the day of the workshop, if we can convince the conference organizers team).

The following speakers have agreed to contribute their provocations:

Martim Brandão is a Lecturer in Robotics and Autonomous Systems in the Department of Informatics at King's College London. Martim's goal is to contribute to the responsible development of robotics and AI. Towards this, he systematically investigates the risks and social impact of robotics and AI, critically examines current approaches to R&D in the field, and develops new algorithms towards more socially just and human-compatible technologies.

Andrew Hundt is a Computing Innovation Fellow at the Robotics Institute at Carnegie Mellon University. He researches human-centered processes, metrics, and algorithms that respect human rights and human needs in AI and Robotics. He earned the competitively awarded Computing Innovation Fellow (CIFellow) sponsored by the Computing Research Association and National Science Foundation, and is at Carnegie Mellon's Robotics Institute working with Prof. Jean Oh. He has quantitatively demonstrated race and gender bias in Robot Learning. His publications extensively critique the ways in which gender and race are addressed in HRI research. He also works on the critical analysis of HRI in relation to disabled people. His recent publication focuses on how LLM-driven robots risk enacting discrimination, violence, and unlawful actions.

David J. Bailey is an Associate Professor in politics at the University of Birmingham. His research and teaching focuses on the political economy of capitalism, with a focus on the different ways in which capitalism is contested. He is a co-founder of the contentious politics of AI network in the university of Birmingham and his research includes how different applications of AI can be contested.

Emanuel Gollob, who is also part of the organizing team, is an artist and researcher in the Creative Robotics department at the University of Arts Linz. He explores the relationships between humans, artificial intelligence and robots, aiming to make alternative ones bodily experienceable. Emanuel´s work has been exhibited at the Smithsonian Arts + Industries Building in Washington, D.C., the Science Gallery Melbourne, and the ArtScience Museum in Singapore.

The tentative schedule of the workshop is as follows:

- 15min Introduction
- 30min Participants' flash introductions of short contributions
- 15min Provocation on Cruel Optimism by Martim Brandão
- 20min Group Debate Cruel Optimism
- 15min Coffee Break
- Provocation on Lucid Despair by Andrew Hundt
- 20min Group Debate Lucid Despair
- 30min Provocations on Precarious Hope by David J. Bailey & Emanuel Gollob
- 20min Group Debate Precarious Hope
- 15min Coffee Break
- 40min Group Activity
- 20min Imaginary HRI conference opening speeches of each group
- 15min Concluding Reflections

4 Documenting the Workshop

A dedicated workshop website will host the organizers' motivation statement, accepted short papers (with the permission of the authors), and later reflections from the workshop itself, making the discussions accessible to the broader HRI community. Both the participants' submissions and the outcomes of the group activity will serve as a foundation for a planned special issue that extends the workshop conversations beyond the space and time of the workshop.

5 Target Audience

This workshop is open to everyone regardless of disciplinary background, career stage, or level of expertise. In total, we aim to bring together between 20-30 participants. We will recruit participants through official calls via popular mailing lists (e.g., hri-announcement, eusset, cscw-sig, chi-announcement), social media, and professional networks. The call for submissions and all the practical information about participation will also be communicated via the workshop website.

Interested participants are invited to submit short contributions (maximum 3 pages if submitted as text) for new orientations for HRI as a field and as a professional event. These need not be traditional papers: we welcome poems, pictorials, manifestos, or any other formats that speak to the participants. The aim is to create a space where diverse modes of expression can surface the range of affects and perspectives present in our community. After the deadline, all submissions will be read by at least two workshop organizers, who will provide short written responses. Our aim is not peer review, but acknowledgment, dialogue, and care for the ideas offered, and shape the themes that will be the ground for the collective activity.

6 Organizers

Anna Dobrosovestnova is a postdoc at the IT:U Interdisciplinary Transformation University, Linz. Her work weaves together social and critical theories and ethnographic approaches to examine the deployment and impact of robots in urban spaces.

Barry Brown is a Professor in Computer Science at the University of Copenhagen. He is interested in interactional perspectives on robots and robots design, and the use of robots for harmful purposes.

Emanuel Gollob is an artist and researcher in the Creative Robotics department at the University of Arts Linz. Through arts-based research, Emanuel investigates today's relationships between humans, artificial intelligence & robots with the goal of making alternative ones bodily experienceable. In parallel, his work traces the change in human perception in connection to digitalization.

Masoumeh Iran Mansouri is an Associate Professor in the School of Computer Science at the University of Birmingham. Her research interests include robot planning in HRI, cultural robotics, and the contentious politics of AI. She is a co-founder of the Critical Cultural Robotics Network and co-leads research on the contentious politics of AI and its alternatives at the University of Birmingham.

Mafalda Gamboa is a design researcher and PhD student at Chalmers University of Technology. Her work is at the intersection of design and human-robot interaction, with a strong interest on ethnography and critical perspectives including unmaking.

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